CHAPTER 85 Coalition Government

MEANING

The term 'coalition' is derived from the Latin word 'coalitio–' which means 'to grow together'. Thus, technically, coalition means the act of uniting parts into one body or whole. Politically, coalition means an alliance of distinct political parties.

Coalition politics or coalition government has been defined in the following way:

When several political parties join hands to form a government and exercise political power on the basis of a common agreed programme/agenda, we can describe the system as coalition politics or coalition government[1].

Coalitions usually occur in modern parliaments when no single political party can muster a majority of votes. Two or more parties, who have enough elected members between them to form a majority, may then be able to agree on a common programme that does not require too many drastic compromises with their individual policies, and can proceed to form a government[2].

Coalition denotes a co-operative arrangement under which distinct political parties, or at all events members of such parties, unite to form a government or ministry[3].

Coalition is a direct descendant of the exigencies of multi-party system in a democratic set-up. It is a phenomenon of a multi-party government where a number of minority parties join hands for the purpose of running the government. A coalition is formed when many splinter groups in a House agree to join hands on a common platform by sinking their broad differences and form a majority in the House[4].

FEATURES

The features or implications of coalition politics or coalition government are very well summarised by J.C. Johari in the following way[5]:

1. Coalitions are formed for the sake of some reward, material or psychic.
2. A coalition implies the existence of at least two partners.
3. The underlying principle of a coalition system stands on the simple fact of temporary conjunction of specific interest.
4. Coalition politics is not a static but a dynamic affair as coalition players and groups dissolve and form new ones.
5. The keynote of coalition politics is compromise, and rigid dogma has no place in it.
6. A coalition government works on the basis of a minimum programme, which may not be ideal for each partner of the coalition.
7. Pragmatism and not ideology is the hallmark of coalition politics. In making political adjustments, principles may have to be set aside.